

The 5-Minute Script to stop any marriage argument *before it starts*

Fighting is normal. Replaying the same fight until both of you feel misunderstood is exhausting.

THE REAL ENEMY

The cycle, not *your spouse*

One person pushes for an answer. The other pulls away to find space. The more one pushes, the more the other retreats. Then the retreat feels like rejection, so the pressure gets louder.

You are not fighting each other. You are getting caught in a pattern that feeds itself.

QUICK CHECK

When tension rises, I usually become the:

Steamroller

I press, explain, repeat, follow, or get louder because I need resolution now.

Turtle

I shut down, go quiet, leave, or avoid because I need safety and space.

Neither role makes you the villain. Both reactions make sense. Left unchecked, they keep the argument alive.

USE THIS TONIGHT

The Circuit Breaker

Five minutes to stop the spiral and protect the connection.

1 NAME THE PATTERN

"We are in the Steamroller-Turtle cycle right now. I do not want to fight you. I want us to slow this down."

2 SAY WHAT IS UNDERNEATH

"I am feeling _____ because _____. What I need right now is _____."

3 MAKE ONE CLEAR REQUEST

"Would you be willing to _____?"

Keep it specific, small, and possible tonight.

REPLACE BLAME WITH CLARITY

INSTEAD OF *"You always ignore me and never help."*

TRY *"I am feeling overwhelmed right now. I need support with _____. Can you help by _____?"*

THE TIME-OUT RULE

"I care about this, and I am too activated to talk well. I need 20 minutes. I will come back at _____:_____ so we can finish this together."

A pause without a return time feels like abandonment. *Set the time, then honor it.*

YOUR FIVE-MINUTE RESET

Write it *before* you say it

A calmer sentence is easier to find on paper than in the middle of a fight.

WHAT HAPPENED, WITHOUT ALWAYS OR NEVER?

WHAT AM I FEELING BENEATH THE ANGER?

WHAT DO I NEED, IN ONE CLEAR SENTENCE?

WHAT SMALL ACTION AM I ASKING FOR?

IF WE PAUSE, WHAT EXACT TIME WILL WE RETURN?

WHEN THE SAME FIGHT KEEPS COMING BACK

A script can interrupt a moment. It cannot undo years of hurt, rebuild broken trust, or teach two nervous systems a new pattern overnight.

You do not have to keep guessing your way through it.

There are two ways to work with Aaron. Which one depends on where you live.

IN THE MEMPHIS AREA

Counseling at the practice

Aaron sees couples through Life Wellness Clinic in Bartlett. Call the office to ask about availability.

901-878-9355

Life Wellness Clinic · Bartlett, TN

OUTSIDE MEMPHIS

Coaching with Aaron

For couples out of state or out of the country. Structured help with a marriage that is workable but stuck.

aarondelaycounseling.com

/counseling · tell him why you're reaching out